

» DAVIS CUP



LISTEN TO OUR
PODCAST



SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

INDIANS PASS THE TOGO TEST

A happy locker room atmosphere and the positive debuts of Rithvik and Singh were **major highlights** for India in its 4-0 domination of the African side.

Nihit Sachdeva

nihit.s@thehindu.co.in

India's 2025 Davis Cup campaign began with a comfortable 4-0 win over lower-ranked and inexperienced Togo in a World Group I Play-Off at the DLTA complex in New Delhi on February 1-2. The victory over Togo was more or less assured when the draw was held in October. What followed in Delhi this month was a mere formality.

The African nation returned to the Davis Cup in 2022 after being absent for almost two decades and started its journey all the way from Group IV (Africa zone). It did well to reach the World Group I Play-Offs by winning 10 of its 11 ties in such a short span. However, it did not face any opponent even close to the level of the current Indian squad, which comprised S. Mukund (World No. 365), Ramkumar Ramanathan (World No. 406) and debutant Karan Singh (World No. 496) as options for singles rubbers. Olympian N. Sriram Balaji (World No. 64) and Rithvik Choudary Bollipalli (World No. 79), another debutant, were selected for doubles.

On the other hand, Togo had just one player with an ATP ranking — Thomas Setodji (World No. 1256), while Liova Ajavon, Hod'abalo Padio and M'lapa Akomlo were the other members, with Alisama Agnamba as the non-playing captain. The gulf in quality was evident. The Togolese simply did not have the level to challenge the host.

With temperatures in the low 20s, fleeting sunlight and barely any strong winds, around 2,000 spectators turned up each day to support the players. Mukund (**left**), playing only his second Davis Cup tie since he cramped and hobbled off the court on his debut against Morocco in Lucknow in 2023, took down Ajavon 6-2, 6-1 before Ramkumar brushed aside Setodji 6-0, 6-2 to give the host a 2-0 lead on day one.

On day two, Rithvik and Balaji put the tie to bed as they took down Akomlo and Padio 6-2, 6-1. Singh and Padio faced each other in the first reverse singles, a dead rubber, and the Indian triumphed 6-2, 6-3. Two of the four rubbers finished in under an hour.

India will next compete in a World Group I tie in September, where a win against its opponent — which will either be one of the winners from the other World Group I Play-Offs or the defeated sides from the 2025 Qualifiers — will ensure a spot in next year's Qualifiers.

India's Davis Cup downfall

India has not reached the Davis Cup Qualifiers since its 1-3 defeat to Croatia in 2021, but the country's struggle to challenge the stronger